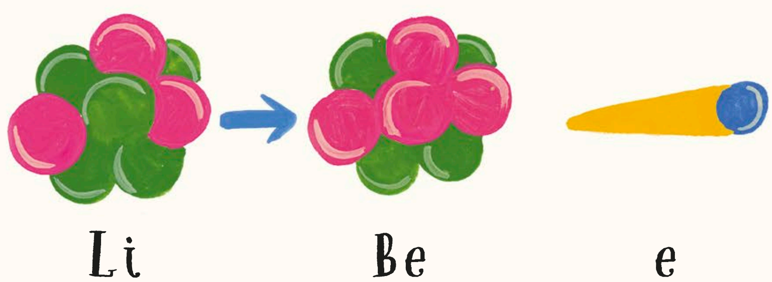
CHIEN-SHIUNG WU

Chinese-American nuclear physicist
1912–1997

Chien-Shiung Wu's story shows that shutting people out of science because of their gender or race is not just unfair, but it can also delay amazing discoveries. Chien-Shiung grew up in a small town in China. She moved to the United States to complete her studies in nuclear physics, but at first found it impossible to get a job as a researcher because she was a woman. Everything changed, however, during World War II. Chien-Shiung began working on the Manhattan Project—a project to build the first nuclear bombs. After the war, she stayed in the US, becoming a professor of physics at Columbia University.

The Manhattan Project taught scientists about radioactivity—when atoms release radioactive energy. Chien-Shiung began studying radioactive atoms that spontaneously (without any help) change into atoms of a different element, releasing tiny, fast-moving electrons in the process. This type of radioactive decay is called beta decay.



Chien-Shiung and her team studied what happened to an atom of lithium (Li) when it decays into an atom of beryllium (Be)—a fast-moving electron (e) is released.